COUNTRY REPORTS: GAMBIA

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# Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

## Governance

### Strategies, plans and policies

The Gambia validates policy faster than it adopts it: a Digital Government Policy and Roadmap was validated in May 2025 under World Bank WARDIP financing, planning a Government Service Bus and an e-government interoperability framework, and a National Data Policy was validated in July 2025 covering data governance and data sovereignty. The budget speech delivered to the National Assembly on 5 December 2025 reported that the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy had begun formulating a National AI and Emerging Technologies Policy, which the ministry reported still under development and not adopted in April 2026. The Government Cloud Policy that accompanies the Government Cloud Strategy 2023-2027 awaits sign-off, its issue and effective dates left blank.

The National Digital Economy Masterplan 2024-2034 is now the overarching strategy for the country's digital agenda, attaching a target year and an estimated cost to each project it plans. The older ICT4D Policy Statement 2018-2028 frames eight pillars, from human capital and e-government to broadband, universal access and cyber-security capability.

The National Broadband Policy 2020-2024 has run its term, and the strategy behind it costed nineteen action plans at D65,000,000 in 2020. The most recent adopted instrument is not digital at all: the country's first unified National Land Policy 2026-2035 was published on 12 August 2026 after a presidential launch on 22 December 2025.

On the Ibrahim Index, The Gambia scored 54.7 out of 100 for overall governance in 2023, 20th of 54 African states and above the continental average, gaining 7.2 points across the decade but losing 0.1 over the most recent five years while the continent gained.

### Legislation and regulation

The Gambia's first comprehensive data-protection statute is law: the National Assembly passed the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Bill 2025 by October 2025, and the enacted Act treats biometric data as sensitive and gives data subjects rights of access, rectification and erasure. The legislature's own bill tracker recorded the bill at "Assented" as at 15 July 2026.

Telecommunications is still governed by the Information and Communications Act 2009, whose Chapter II Part XIII carries the older provisions on processing personal data, privacy of communications and interception. The Communication Bill 2025, which would modernise that Act and reach cybercrime, data protection and legal recognition of electronic signatures, contracts and transactions, was moved for second reading on 3 March 2026 and referred to committee, members having raised its silence on surveillance powers. As at July 2026 it was still before parliamentary committees.

Most new rulemaking is arriving as ministerial instruments rather than statute. PURA put draft Broadcasting and Online Content Regulations 2026 out for consultation in April 2026 alongside six other drafts, made by the minister under section 226(1) of the 2009 Act — so the country's online-content rules face no second reading, committee stage or vote. Draft enforcement regulations would build a single compliance, penalty and appeal code across every regulated sector, draft unified fees regulations a single fee code, and draft complaints and consumer-protection regulations a consumer right to complain with timelines, hearings and appeals.

Elsewhere the pipeline is early. A Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Bill received its first reading on 5 March 2026; a State Intelligence Service Bill had been validated at a workshop by 31 July 2026. The Statistics Act 2005 remains the constitutive statistics law, and no general artificial-intelligence legislation was in force or before the legislature as at June 2026.

### Data protection

The Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025 establishes an independent oversight Commission, and the bill laid before the National Assembly made the Information Commission that authority, with powers to investigate complaints, enter and search premises, impose fines and issue enforcement notices — a single body holding both the access-to-information mandate it was created with in 2021 and the data protection one. Controllers must notify the Commission within 72 hours of becoming aware of a breach, and notify affected individuals without undue delay where the risk is high, with criminal penalties for concealment. Individuals gained rights to be informed, to access, rectify and erase their data and to object, and the bill set a one-month deadline for answering an access request. The Commission took full voting membership of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities on 10 June 2026.

The statute closes an obligation that had stood since 2010, when ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 required each member state to establish a legal framework and an independent supervisory authority, with Article 36 permitting transfers to non-member countries only where protection is adequate and only on prior notification of that authority. On the continental instrument, The Gambia signed the Malabo Convention on 2 December 2022 and committed to ratify it so that it could be domesticated.

Two gaps sit alongside the new law. Government data residency rests on a Government Cloud Policy that awaits sign-off and covers the government sector only, not a general legal localisation rule. And state access to communications is governed by nothing new: members raised the bill's silence on surveillance powers at the Communication Bill's second reading on 3 March 2026, and the National Intelligence Agency has been renamed the State Intelligence Service ahead of a bill that had reached validation, not enactment, by 31 July 2026. Police data collection has meanwhile been running since the WAPIS-DACORE centre was inaugurated on 14 October 2021 with ECOWAS, INTERPOL and the EU. On the Ibrahim Index, protection against discrimination is the country's worst indicator of any kind, scoring 0.0 out of 100 in 2023 and down 8.3 points over the decade.

### Regional collaboration

The Gambia lost the ECOWAS Commission's presidency on 31 August 2026, when Omar Alieu Touray handed over to General Birame Diop of Senegal after a four-year tenure, with Ghana's Amin Amidu Sulemani taking the infrastructure, energy and digitalisation portfolio at the same handover.

Roaming is where regional obligation has actually bitten. PURA and Senegal's ARTP signed a memorandum in December 2025 to implement the ECOWAS Community Roaming Regulation, capping voice, SMS and data charges, granting thirty consecutive free incoming-call days and setting up joint anti-fraud monitoring, with services to begin on 1 March 2026; the regulator names equivalent agreements already held with Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Sierra Leone and Liberia. ECOWAS ministers meeting at Cotonou had required full implementation by all mobile operators by the end of 2025, and a Lomé experts' meeting in August 2025 tracked progress through bilateral tariff agreements

rather than any new instrument. The wider bilateral relationship with Senegal has moved into implementation around connectivity, cybersecurity, skills and digital transformation since a June 2026 ministerial memorandum, with the two regulators separately deepening frequency coordination and quality-of-service work.

Continental commitments remain partly unfinished. The Gambia signed the Malabo Convention at Addis Ababa on 2 December 2022, joining fourteen other signatory states, and undertook to ratify it so that it could be domesticated; the communications ministry told a United Nations commission in April 2024 that the government had ratified it in March 2024, and the repository holds no instrument of ratification or deposit. It is bound by ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 on personal data protection, annexed to the ECOWAS Treaty as an integral part of it, whose Article 2 requires a national legal framework and whose Article 14 requires an independent data protection authority. The Information Commission won full voting membership of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities on 10 June 2026.

Regional machinery is thinner than the meeting schedule suggests. A draft directive governing electronic communications in West Africa, started in 2019, was still short of adoption at a September 2025 validation workshop, and the ECOWAS Community budget for 2026-2028 carries no digital appropriation, its one ICT-named line left at nil. The country nonetheless scores 60.1 out of 100 on regional integration in 2023, 10th of 54 and up 17.4 points over the decade.

### Standards

The Gambia's national standards catalogue contains almost no ICT-specific standards — its electrotechnical section consists of adopted IEC entries only, and many catalogue entries are marked draft or withdrawn and are therefore not operative. The Gambia Standards Bureau, established by the TGSB Act 2010, publishes the Gambian Standards series by ICS class across management, food, building, metrology, halal, petroleum, packaging, electrotechnical, transport, and water and sanitation.

Internationally the Bureau holds ISO Correspondent membership, with participating and observing places on ISO technical committees, and is a member of the International Electrotechnical Commission. It has been the country's WTO Technical Barriers to Trade enquiry point since 2014. ISO's secretary-general visited on 29-30 June 2026 and pressed the country to move from adopting international standards to contributing to them by placing Gambian experts on technical committees.

Where digital standards exist they are assigned rather than written. The National Digital Addressing Policy gives the Bureau the technical standards and GICTA the national digital addressing databases and portals; GICTA's published account of its statutory functions claims enforcement of standards for government hardware, software and databases, custody of a national data bank and coordination of government e-signature infrastructure. The land policy commits the government to develop geo-information data standards and a nationwide unique property identifier for a computerised Land Information System, setting neither itself. Regionally, as at April 2024, ECOWAS and the EU D4D Hub had formulated guidelines for certified electronic signatures while the roadmap was still being defined.

### Public debate and participation in policymaking

The Gambia ranks first of all 54 African states on public perception of freedom of speech, at 90.3 out of 100 in 2023, with digital freedom at 84.6 (5th, up 44.6 points over the decade) and media freedom at 66.8 (10th). Against that standing, the regulator is consulting on a regime that would register the people who speak.

PURA opened a public consultation on seven draft instruments by notice dated 1 April 2026, with the comment window running 1 to 10 April. Among them, Part V of the draft Broadcasting and Online Content Regulations provides for registration of designated online content providers, registration of journalists and a register of journalists, and a separate registration regime with its own application procedure for "Social Media Users with Significant Public Reach". The same draft puts content-monitoring and editorial duties on intermediaries and reaches foreign platforms, tiers online actors from internet service providers to content aggregators, establishes a Content Complaints Committee, and runs from prohibited content through political and electoral coverage to rules for live broadcasting — and it would be made by ministerial regulation under the 2009 Act, with no parliamentary stage at which any of it is debated.

Civil society has organised around the one instrument that does have a parliamentary stage. Gambia Participates convened members of the Human Rights and Constitutional Matters and Education and ICT committees with the Gambia Press Union and the Media Council on 18 July 2026, where the union set out the restrictive media laws it wants repealed; the organisers noted that lawmakers could not publicly discuss a bill before committees but could hear stakeholders' concerns.

The state has also entered the information-integrity business directly. The Ministry of Information's national misinformation and disinformation response centre, Factguard, takes public submissions of messages, photos, videos and links by free hotline, checks them against stated evidence using trained human analysts, and publishes every determination with its sources and reasoning on a public audit trail. The August 2023 stakeholder engagement plan for the World Bank-financed WARDIP separately sets the programme's consultation, disclosure and grievance arrangements.

## Finance

### Financial sustainability

The state's own money carries 41.0 per cent of the digital lines in The Gambia's approved 2026 budget, GMD 661.9 million of GMD 1,612.4 million, against 20.8 per cent of GMD 2,457.6 million in 2025. The treasury-funded lines of the Public Administration Modernization Project come to GMD 253.6 million in 2026, against GMD 77.2 million in 2025.

The swing is on the external side. The World Bank's regional digital integration programme, whose grant closes on 29 December 2028, carried GMD 1,945.7 million of IDA money in the digital ministry's 2025 budget; the 2026 budget carries GMD 516.7 million under it, beside a new GMD 433.9 million IDA line for regional statistics harmonisation.

The lines that keep the state's own systems running are on the treasury: the 2026 budget puts GMD 70.4 million of domestic money into application software and licences for the government's financial systems, GMD 20.0 million into developing the integrated financial management system, and GMD 7.2 million into data storage facilities and fees for the modernisation project.

Where the private sector carries a public network, the state has declined to stand behind it: the communications minister told lawmakers in December 2025 that the private partner taking on a state operator's network would build, operate and transfer it without any government guarantee and under a performance bond, but did not give the number of years.

### MoUs and other agreements

The most recent of The Gambia's digital memoranda put four parties on the same page over telecom tax: the Gambia Revenue Authority, the Public Utilities Regulatory Authority, SICPA and Vista Bank signed on 15 April 2026 to work toward a revenue assurance system covering the mobile operators. A year earlier the government had signed with the Kalp Foundation, in January 2025, to build a blockchain-based digital public infrastructure platform branded "Gambia One". India's foreign ministry records a memorandum on digital public infrastructure cooperation signed in October 2024, alongside the e-VBAB scholarship arrangement in place since March 2020 under which Gambian students study online.

Individual ministries and agencies have signed on their own account: the Accountant General's Department with SUTURA in July 2026 on digital revenue collection, the Ministry of Higher Education, Research, Science and Technology with the African Institute for Mathematical Sciences in December 2025 toward a satellite centre in the country, and PURA with Senegal's ARTP toward implementing the ECOWAS community roaming regulation.

### New investments

The Gambia's largest external commitment to its digital estate is an IDA grant of SDR 38.1 million, signed on 14 December 2023 and closing on 29 December 2028, US$50.0 million equivalent, under the Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program, funding telecommunications regulatory capacity and submarine infrastructure for the first phase of the Amilcar Cabral cable. The country is not among the beneficiaries of that programme's second phase, a US$137 million operation announced in March 2026 for Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone. The World Bank separately approved US$160 million in IDA financing on 24 June 2026 for an electricity access project covering Togo and The Gambia jointly.

Two transactions dominate, both aimed at state-owned operators: YCELL's July 2026 agreement to take an 80 per cent stake in GAMCEL with a network modernisation programme attached, and SYSROAD's public-private partnership with GAMTEL, signed in December 2025 to modernise the national broadband network, behind which sits the 2017 China Eximbank concessional loan for the Gambia National Broadband Network. The government also signed a contract with Margins ID Systems in January 2026 for national identity cards on a build, co-operate and transfer model. The rest is small and largely grant-funded: the Gates Foundation's now-closed payments pilot, an African Development Bank grant for unique bank identification across the West African Monetary Zone and the EU-funded DHIS2 platform tracking the national development plan.

Fourteen distinct commitments are on record as at September 2026, announced between September 2016 and August 2026, ten of them country-specific and four regional operations naming The Gambia as a beneficiary. Eight are grants, three concessional loans, two equity and one a public-private partnership, and eight financiers stand behind them, the African Development Bank and the World Bank most often with four and three. Connectivity draws the largest number, five of fourteen, ahead of government and e-government systems with three and digital payments with two. Most of the money is not yet moving: the largest three, led by YCELL's GAMCEL programme, are recorded as approved rather than disbursing, and the African Development Bank's DIGEST and SHyMeR operations remain at pipeline stage. The weight of it sits with the two state-owned operators.

## ICT Infrastructure

### Connectivity

The mobile network was renumbered on 4 September 2026, existing numbers taking a two-digit operator prefix — 87 for Africell, 83 for QCell, 86 for Comium — while Gamcel keeps its seven-digit numbers in this phase. Reach is the older problem: the country's internet went down nationwide in the early hours of 4 June 2026, after more than two weeks of electricity outages, with Gamtel confirming the failure and subscribers of Africell, Comium and other providers dependent on national infrastructure cut off with it.

Just under half of Gambians used the internet in 2024, 49.5% against 45.9% a year earlier, and roughly two-thirds lived under a 4G signal that year. Active mobile subscriptions reached 3,484,313 in 2024, up from 3,159,599 in 2023, across seven named internet service providers — a count of SIMs, not of people. A gigabyte of mobile data cost USD 1.80 a month in 2021, 1.5% of monthly income per head and inside the affordability threshold. Price became a street issue in 2025: police arrested 19 protesters outside the regulator on 22 August 2025 over its D50-per-gigabyte minimum data tariff, and the regulator set mobile data at D75 per gigabyte from 1 January 2026, ending the floor.

Gambians' own verdict on their infrastructure has collapsed: public perception of infrastructure scored 32.4 out of 100 in 2023, down 34.5 points since 2014 and the third most deteriorated of the country's 96 governance indicators. Infrastructure is the worst-scoring governance sub-category, at 33.7 out of 100 and 33rd of 54 African states, and internet and computers, up 19.7 points over the decade, still scores 26.4 and ranks 35th.

The Broadband Strategy 2020-2024 set targets of 5 Mbps for every subscriber, broadband coverage above 90% and 4G coverage above 85% by 2024, behind an action plan costed at D65,000,000. The money since has come from outside: the World Bank approved an IDA grant of SDR 38.1 million, US$50.0 million equivalent, in November 2023 under a regional digital integration programme running to 2028 with the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy implementing, and GAMTEL signed a US$50 million partnership with SYSROAD SA HOLDING on 24 December 2025 to modernise the national broadband network.

Starlink paid its licence fee in December 2024 and was still without a licence more than a year later, the minister declining to sign a VSAT licence for a company that is not a VSAT operator. International capacity through the incumbent stood at 25 Gbps over four ACE gateways, with a 28 Gbps backup link through a Senegalese operator (September 2026), and a second submarine cable was still at bid evaluation in July 2026. Domestic traffic exchange has not moved either: the Serekunda Internet Exchange Point, founded in July 2013 by fourteen members including Africell, Gamtel, QCell and PURA and addressed care of Gamtel's Serekunda exchange, publishes no current capacity or participant figure. Government traffic has its own wireless network: the government 4G LTE network serving offices and officials grew from four base stations to eight in 2022.

### Data Storage

The Gambia opened two data centres within three months of each other in 2026: QGroup House on Kairaba Avenue, presented as the country's first data centre and inaugurated on 29 April 2026, its size and capacity undisclosed, and a National Data Centre at Abuko, inaugurated by President Barrow on 30 June 2026 with the launch of the National Identity Management System. The Abuko facility was developed by the supplier Margins ID Group, which also supplied the financing and long-term operational support.

Before them the government ran on a Tier-2 data centre managed by the state operator Gamtel, with a Tier-4 facility under consideration. The Government Cloud Strategy 2023-2027 records that power connectivity is not sufficient and reliable to support the country's existing data centres, naming frequent power outages and fluctuations as risks

of data loss and downtime, while Gamtel was buying generators as backup for the data centre and power and cooling cost comparatively more in The Gambia. The financial management system already ran from primary and disaster-recovery data centres in 2017, and Gamtel rents site, tower and rack space at 43 sites to ISPs and small businesses (October 2026).

Where government data must sit is written down but not yet binding. The Government Cloud Policy sets a data-residency rule at its data-sovereignty section, keyed to its own data classification, requiring data classified as Classified to be stored and processed in-country on a government private cloud or on-premise; the policy awaits sign-off, its issue and effective dates left blank, so the rule is drafted rather than in force. Outside the government sector there is no general data localisation mandate: the data protection bill laid before the National Assembly permits cross-border transfers of personal data where the receiving country's law or binding safeguards ensure an appropriate level of protection.

### Energy

Power cuts had run for nearly two weeks by early June 2026, some communities going more than 24 hours without electricity, and NAWEC put the crisis down to maintenance challenges and equipment rehabilitation.

The National Energy Compact puts average national electricity access at 73.7% on a 2024 baseline against a target of 100% by 2030, and the average conceals the country's real division: access stood at 85.3% in urban areas against 35.3% in rural ones in 2023. 645 communities remained unelectrified (2025) and the compact puts public and private funding needs to 2030 at US$552 million (2025). Delivery leans on the grid: on-grid connection is the main path given the country's geography, mini-grids are confined to areas where extension is unfeasible, and a national tariff-equalisation policy requires subsidy for mini-grid operators. Inaugurations of completed access projects were scheduled nationwide between 7 and 15 February 2026, covering 719 beneficiary communities under the GERMP, GEAP and ECOREAP programmes.

What power there is costs more than almost anywhere. The average tariff is around USD 0.21 per kilowatt-hour, which the World Bank's public finance review ranks among the highest globally and attributes to the sector's weak financial performance and system losses, with reliance on heavy fuel oil exposing it to oil-price and exchange-rate shocks. Renewables account for about 13% of the overall supply mix once imported regional hydropower is counted, against a 2030 target of 30%. Access to energy scores 31.9 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, up 5.4 points over the decade.

The digital estate sits on top of that. The government's own cloud strategy records power as not sufficient and reliable for the country's data centres, and the nationwide internet outage of 4 June 2026 arrived after more than two weeks of electricity outages.

### Technical Capacity

The country's organised software developer community is small enough to count: Google Developer Group Banjul lists fewer than a thousand members (2026).

The Civil Service Reform Programme 2018-2027 requires capacity building after its predecessor's did not take place, and the Civil Service University's ICT department, running since the late 1990s, lists Cisco network-certification and cyber-security courses. Formal provision beyond it is narrow: three accredited institutions offer ICT and computer science programmes. The E-Government Strategy 2021-2024 left an interoperability framework of policies, standards and guidelines for the ICT Agency to apply across government.

Administrative capability has moved in the opposite direction from the infrastructure it has to run on. Effective administration and the capacity of the statistical system both rose sharply over 2014-2023 and now rank inside the continent's top twenty, while the governance category housing infrastructure, public administration and the rural economy is the one in which most sub-categories deteriorated. The statistical system's own review found more than a third of national statistical system members unaware that the Statistics Act existed.

Some systems are built at home: the pensions directorate's software was developed by the deputy accountant general's team and validated internally in June 2024, and the public service ministry and the accountant general's department were building a human-resources and payroll data warehouse with dashboards in March 2025.

Capacity in the digital estate arrives with projects rather than with budget lines. The WARDIP financing agreement obliges a project steering committee, a technical committee and an implementation unit inside the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy; the national incident-response team's 2026 staff training was delivered by the ITU and financed through the same World Bank programme; and a two-week certified course in results-based management and ICT data analytics opened in July 2026, its participants expected to build and maintain dashboards afterwards.

### Cybersecurity

The Gambia's binding computer-misuse and cybercrime law is still Chapter III Part III of the Information and Communications Act 2009, assented in May 2009 and never displaced by a dedicated statute. A Cybercrime Bill introduced in March 2024 had not been enacted as at June 2026, the press union naming it in May 2026 among pending laws that threaten media freedom, and the Communication Bill 2025, which would reach cybercrime, data protection and the legal recognition of electronic signatures and contracts, stood referred to committee after the motion for its second reading on 3 March 2026.

The policy layer is in the same condition. The National Cybersecurity Strategy covered the period 2020 to 2024, and cyber-security capability is one of the eight pillars of the ICT for Development Policy Statement 2018-2028. Measured on declared instruments rather than tested defences, that adds up to a middling result: the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024 places The Gambia in its 'establishing' tier, for scores of 55 to 85 out of 100.

Operationally the country has a national computer security incident response team, gmCSIRT, whose staff were trained in May 2026 on the incident-response and threat-intelligence toolchain they are expected to operate, naming RTIR, T-Pot, MISP and Taranis NG, financed through the World Bank's WARDIP programme and delivered by the ITU.

Cybersecurity is one of the four priorities under which the Senegal-Gambia telecommunications memorandum moved into implementation in 2026, and it sits within the declared threat frame of the State Intelligence Service, the renamed National Intelligence Agency, alongside espionage, disinformation and transnational organised crime.

## DPI

### Data Exchange

Interoperability across The Gambia's main population systems is measured at zero. The World Bank's supervision of the Resilience, Inclusion, Skills and Equity project records a January 2024 baseline of no interoperability across the Gambia Social Registry, the education management information systems, civil registration and health insurance, and a value still of 0 at 25 November 2025 with one instance being verified, against a target of at least three systems interoperable by October 2028 carrying a US$500,000 performance-based allocation.

There is no operational national exchange to connect them: data exchange is classified as planned or piloted (October 2024). The gap is long-standing: the Ministry's own E-Government Strategy 2021–2024, dated October 2020, calls for an e-Government Interoperability Framework of policies, standards and guidelines for the ICT Agency to apply, and the strategy's implementation window closed in 2024.

Work has resumed at the framework layer. The Gambia validated a National Enterprise Architecture framework under the GovStack initiative with ITU support in May 2026, presented as a unified blueprint for interoperable, citizen-centric services; the Digital Government Policy and Roadmap validated in May 2025 plans a Government Service Bus; and the Government Open Data Strategy 2024–2027 proposes a secure data-exchange pilot of the X-Road kind. None of them names an exchange in service.

The one dated exchange commitment with a named counterparty runs outward. The second Gambia–Senegal Monitoring Committee, meeting at Saly on 16–17 July 2026, agreed to exchange customs data by API once the GAINDE system is installed at Karang, Keur Ayib and Selety within three months, to deploy SIGMAT for real-time transit tracking and to reactivate the EnCen intelligence-sharing platform. Inside government the foundational links are still absent: the regulator's SIM registration database is still planned and has no electronic identity authentication, and the social registry is not linked to the foundational identity system. The 2026 budget speech names integration and interoperability in the payments space as a priority for the year.

### Digital Identity and CRVS

The Gambia replaced its national identity system in mid-2026. President Barrow launched the National Identity Management System on 29–30 June 2026, a single unified National Identity Register with biometric enrolment and chip-based cards in place of fragmented identity records, and he received the first GAM ID card at the launch. Phase one of enrolment, for citizens aged 18 and over, began on 4 August 2026 at seven Greater Banjul centres, with a published schedule taking issuance upcountry in three tranches between 7 and 21 September 2026. The card it replaces had reached about 60% of adults (2024).

Identity could not be checked online in 2024. The card then in issue supported on-card and offline authentication only, with no authentication services across government (2024), bank know-your-customer checks lacked electronic identity authentication and relied on paper-based identity documents, and manual passports remained in circulation with duplicates issued, there being no biometric deduplication between the passport system and the identity database (2024).

The system is privately financed. Government signed a build, co-operate and transfer contract with Margins ID Systems Applications in January 2026, running eight years with the supplier bearing the build cost and taking 70% of revenue, with free replacement of all valid existing cards and ten years of validity on the new card, and the register runs on a National Data Centre at Abuko inaugurated alongside it. The legal framework for identity carries gaps in inclusion, data protection, cybersecurity and cross-border recognition (2025).

Access carries a price and an age floor. The card costs 450 dalasi, the same for first issuance, renewal and replacement and for vulnerable groups, and eligibility begins at 18, children being assigned a national identification number at birth through the electronic civil registration system. The health and interior ministries signed a memorandum on 22 March 2024 to generate one national identity number across the identity system and the electronic civil register, starting with a file transfer of issued-card records. The credential is a dual-interface biometric ECOWAS card compliant with both ECOWAS and ICAO standards, though The Gambia is not among the states financed by the World Bank's WURI identification programme. An immigration officer testified on 6 October 2026 that the department no longer has access to data generated under the former biometric identity system, leaving open who holds the historical records.

### Digital Payments and Fintech

The Gambia got a real-time national payment rail in December 2025. BANTABA 2.0 went live on 15 December 2025, a Mojaloop-based inclusive instant payment system operated by Gamswitch that clears and settles across banks, mobile money operators, microfinance institutions and fintechs. It was built under the Gambia Interoperability Switch Programme led by the Central Bank and the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy, and the operator describes what is live as a first phase.

The money moving through the wider fintech sector is measured quarterly: cash-in rose 4.4% to D28.2 billion and cash-out 5.3% to D32.1 billion between the first and second quarters of 2026. The count of people behind it is not. The Central Bank's August 2026 Monetary Policy Committee release carries transaction values alone, with neither a registered-user nor an active-user figure, three months after the Committee itself called for further analysis of why registrations had fallen.

Five Central Bank publications between December 2025 and August 2026 give four different readings of the same registered fintech-user series, two of them issued on the same day and contradicting each other, leaving the March 2026 count unresolved.

Reach is uneven. Six commercial banks are live on the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System as at April 2026, and no Gambian mobile-money operator or wallet appears on that list. Government has begun paying and collecting through them: the Nafa cash transfer has paid bi-monthly grants to more than 15,000 rural households cashlessly through Wave since January 2026, and Yonna Wallet became the first Gambian fintech authorised to collect payments for all government services through the Accountant General's Department (March 2026).

The governing instruments lag the systems. Digital retail payments run under the Central Bank's 2011 mobile money regulation, whose section 8.1 obliges licensed providers to use systems capable of both domestic and international interoperability — a duty to be capable, not a duty to interoperate. Access to banking services is one of the country's ten worst-scoring governance indicators, at 15.4 out of 100 in 2023 and up only 1.2 points over the decade.

### Registries

The Gambia's land register is on paper, and the software built to change that is not being used: a National Assembly committee found in November 2025 that a UNDP-funded digital workflow system for land administration has gone unused while the land and deeds registry under the Lands (Registration of Deeds) Act 1980 remains a manual system. It is a deeds record rather than a cadastre or parcel index. The National Land Policy 2026–2035, published in August 2026, mandates a digitalised National Land Administration System, a centralised Land Information System and digitised land registration, and the only cadastral mapping under way is a single-area pilot at Kotu Stream tendered under the WACA coastal project.

Civil registration is the working exception. The electronic Civil Registration and Vital Statistics system, launched in August 2022, replaced paper birth registration and issues digital birth certificates carrying a unique national identification number, cumulative registrations passing 1.4 million by June 2026 against 1.17 million in February 2023. Marriage registration and divorce certificates are handled separately, by application form, at the Ministry of Justice's marriage registry (2024).

The social registry is the most used database in government. Fifteen programmes drew on the Gambia Social Registry to select beneficiaries as at November 2025, against a closing target of eight, with coverage steady at 43 districts; it held around 203,000 households, roughly 70% of the population, in 2024. It is also unconnected: the social registry is not linked to the foundational identity system, and the Social Security and Housing Finance Corporation keeps its own separate seven-digit identifier.

The other registers sit apart from one another too. Business registration runs online through the Single Window Registry. The Independent Electoral Commission maintains a mature, continuously updated nationwide biometric voter register, which was not linked to the foundational identity system (2024), while a fresh biometric registration exercise runs to October 2026. And Kanifing Municipality's digital address database, built between July 2021 and February 2022 over 36,000 georeferenced properties, serves the council's waste management and property-tax collection (2025). The largest opposition party said in October 2026 that the supplementary register dataset it was given holds 183,163 records against 212,095 registrations announced, and that the commission had not answered its requests for the de-duplication figures.

### Sectoral management information systems

Domestic tax administration was still largely manual as at June 2026, the Integrated Tax Administration System having reached taxpayer sensitisation but not rollout, so e-registration, e-filing and e-payment are not live. The build has already survived a supplier failure: the contract was first awarded to SOGEMA Technologies of Canada, which went bankrupt, after which an Arabsoft and Tunisie Micro-Informatique consortium was engaged at USD 7,270,192.20 in October 2025 — a 24-month build designed to interoperate with the Central Bank, the Accountant General's Department, the Companies Registry, the national identity system and ASYCUDA World.

Customs is the digitised end of revenue. The deployed stack comprises ASYCUDA World for clearance, a National Single Window, automated weighbridges, OCR cameras at all entry and exit points and a traceability solution using electronically verifiable excise stamps (March 2026), alongside a Digital Tax Invoicing System launched in July 2025.

The sectoral systems are further along than the links between them. The Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education has run a DHIS2-based education management information system since 2018 and the SEMIS App was scaled nationally by 2021, capturing learner data on offline-capable devices, and the higher-education ministry launched an app for tertiary institutions with timetabling, course registration and fee payment in April 2025; the Health Management Information System identifies patients by the national identification number generated at civil registration; and the two ministries signed a memorandum of understanding in July 2026 to link them, with the integration not yet operational. Immunisation and child-health data at Smart Paper Technology facilities is still entered on structured paper forms, then scanned and synchronised with DHIS2 (2025).

Policing still runs on paper. The Inspector General of Police confirmed publicly in March 2026 that the force still documents its work on paper, and its own arrest and detention procedure prescribes paper instruments alone, naming no digital case-recording tool. The courts are further on: computer-aided transcription runs in six courts with electronic filing, fee payment and case assignment, but the Chief Justice said in January 2026 that suspended donor funding had stalled its expansion. Elsewhere a DHIS2-based platform tracking the national development plan across ministries was built with European Union funding of EUR 493,346, covering 237 indicators across the plan's seven pillars, and a Labour Market and Migration Information System linked to the job centres was not yet fully operational (2026). The national health policy described the health management information system as paper at facilities and electronic at the seven regional directorates and the ministry. The main referral hospital launched a pilot of an electronic medical record developed by the medical research unit (2023).

### Other GovTech and e-Gov

Gambians can pay the state digitally sooner than they can transact with it. Yonna Wallet became the first Gambian fintech authorised to collect payments for all government services through the Accountant General's Department, with auto-generated traceable receipts and a channel for diaspora payments (March 2026), and work is under way

on a GovPay platform to bring public-sector payments across ministries onto one monitored channel. The government's own account of why 2025 non-tax revenue reached only 66% of target, at D4.05 billion, named the absence of digital payment systems among the reasons.

Delivery of the services themselves is thinner. The Gambia scored 0.2552 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, ranking 181st, and Gambians rate obtaining an identity document at 38.4 out of 100 in 2023, 21st of 54 African states and up only 7.8 points over the decade. A MyGov platform carrying identity-card, passport and immigration workflows is built but not launched, held up by unresolved contracts over passport issuance, with rollout targeted before the end of 2026 (September 2026).

Where services have been digitised they are single-agency. Business registration runs online through the Single Window Registry; customs runs a full digital stack while domestic tax administration remained largely manual as at June 2026; UNDP tendered in March 2026 for an integrated digital case management system for the justice and interior ministries and the judiciary, a year after seeking consultants for a feasibility study of one for the justice ministry; and no land information system is in operation, an assessment having been conducted to evaluate structures for one (March 2026), and in September 2026 the lands minister told the National Assembly that contracts for World Bank-supported land digitalisation had been awarded. Marriage registration runs through its own registry at the Ministry of Justice.

The institutional machinery is being assembled ahead of the services. A National Digital Addressing Steering Committee was launched in October 2025, a National Enterprise Architecture framework was validated under the GovStack initiative with ITU support in May 2026, and the Ministry of Information runs Factguard, a national misinformation and disinformation response centre that takes public submissions through a free hotline and has them checked by trained human analysts against stated evidence. The government began issuing a biometric driving licence valid for three years, replacing annual renewal (2026). The finance ministry introduced a digital duty waiver application system, committing to a decision within 72 hours where requirements are met, reported on 30 September 2026.

The procurement authority trained a second cohort of its cadre from 8 to 10 October 2026 on the 2022 Act, the 2024 Regulations and the rollout of the Electronic Government Procurement system, with the new instruments mandatory from January 2027.

## Digitalisation

### Digitalisation of sub-national government

Whether the state's financial management system works at the country's largest council is in open dispute between two arms of government: in August 2026 the Accountant General's Department publicly rejected Kanifing Municipal Council mayor Talib Bensouda's account of the council's use of the Integrated Financial Management Information System, offering ledgers and expenditure reports it had generated for the council as evidence the system is in use there.

Sub-national digital government otherwise rests on a single instrument. The National Digital Addressing Policy (2023) makes local governments the custodians of digital addresses and of their own local address databases rather than consumers of a nationally held dataset, requires each to operate a local digital address portal carrying region-wide spatial data, and provides for those local databases to be shared with a national database held by the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy, with development and management of the national and local databases and portals falling to the Gambia Information and Communication Technology Agency and technical standards to the Gambia Standards Bureau.

One council has built to it. Kanifing has tied digital address codes, built on Google Plus Codes and displayed on compound gates, to properties' geographic coordinates and into its municipal property-rates register, and its rates manager said collectors now work from tablets that navigate to a registered property by its address rather than by the owner's name (June 2026). The council expects the codes to improve emergency response and rates collection, and is adding street numbering alongside them.

The Greater Banjul Area Sustainable Urban Development Programme 2020-40 is supported by an African Development Bank Transition Support Facility grant covering capacity building and implementation of the Greater Banjul Digital Master Plan.

The finance ministry's 2024 progress report put the system in all area councils, with one council fully on it and most on unreliable links. Its 2025 performance report recorded untrained users at Basse and bandwidth shortages at Brikama. The April 2026 end evaluation found it fully used only in Kerewan, with the councils' revenue system still unlinked.

### Rural digital data capture

Health data is still captured on paper where the patient is: Smart Paper Technology has maternal, child and immunisation data entered on structured paper forms that are then scanned and synchronised with DHIS2, and a TB e-Tracker pilot at eleven facilities, rural ones among them, took its case data from the facilities' paper registers onto tablets (2025). Civil registration is the exception: the Ministry of Health has replaced the paper system with an electronic one and extended satellite internet to health facilities including rural ones, which the 2026 budget speech ties to birth registration rather than care (December 2025).

The National Digital Economy Masterplan 2024-2034 extends the fibre backbone outward from the Greater Banjul Area, calls for projects to connect remote and underserved areas and makes a secondary submarine cable a priority. The rural economy those services would reach scored 57.8 out of 100 in 2023, 29th of 54 African states; access to markets, physical and institutional, fell 13.7 points over the decade to 63.0, its sharpest-falling component. Rural electricity access remains far below the urban rate (2023), which bounds what a village facility can run.

Education is the one sector built for the offline case. The ministry has run a DHIS2-based education management information system since 2018, whose teacher attendance component reports by structured SMS where there is no connectivity, and the SEMIS school system captures learner data on offline-capable devices (2025). It earns its keep: few schools have internet for teaching or computers to teach on, and many lower basic schools have no electricity (2025).

Policing has had no such design: the Inspector General of Police said in March 2026 that the force still documents its work on paper, and its arrest and detention manual prescribes paper instruments alone — the station diary, the pocket diary, the Diary of Action.

Three digital policing programmes are on record — a 2021 West African Police Information System commitment, a 2026 automated fingerprint identification milestone and a 2025 case-management result — and none puts digital capture at a rural police post.

## Technology

### AI

The most visible artificial-intelligence initiative in Gambian government does not claim to use artificial intelligence. The National Misinformation and Disinformation Response Centre's own public site describes a process of human analyst review, and the centre was launched on 27 April 2026 with ECOWAS funding, built by the Gambian firm Dundal Systems and organised around three pillars — detect, verify, respond.

Behind that, the state has little to run models on. The national digital economy masterplan records that The Gambia has never had an AI policy and strategy, and calls for a real-time data analytics system for government that is still to be built.

The revenue authority already uses machine learning: it chooses property owners for rental-tax audit from rental valuations a vendor's model built on pooled tax, utility, municipal and telecom records, with the vendor owning the outputs (May 2026). Its wider plan is unfunded on its own face: the Gambia Revenue Authority's 2025-2029 corporate strategic plan sets project IE06 to pilot big data, cloud computing, AI, machine learning, IoT and APIs in 2026-2027 at D10.4 million, under a cost column headed "project cost (not funded)".

Nothing in law reaches the technology directly. No general AI legislation was in force as at June 2026, no AI legislation was proposed, and there were no dedicated rules on risks such as hallucination or deepfakes; the same assessment maps AI-adjacent data handling onto the constitutional privacy and fair-trial guarantees, the Criminal Procedure Code 1993 and the data-protection statute as the closest applicable framework. The national AI policy and strategy was still under development when the communications ministry addressed the UN Commission on Science and Technology for Development in April 2026.

Use is running ahead of both. Gambia Participates' founder reported AI-generated images being used to build false narratives during the supplementary voter-registration exercise (June 2026), and the same donor-funded programme has trained journalists and fact-checkers in Kololi in using AI to debunk. Local-language work is private: an open-source Mandinka-English translation model was released in April 2026, and a memorandum signed in May 2026 between a Singapore AI firm and a Banjul innovation hub sets out to build Mandinka, Wolof and Fula datasets. Teaching capacity sits at the University of The Gambia, whose ICT school runs a six-month diploma in artificial intelligence alongside data science and cybersecurity.

### ICT Industry

The sector shrank while the investment announcements grew: Gambian ICT gross value added fell between 2023 and 2024, from around 3.5% of GDP to around 2.4%, with sector employment of 2,922 in 2024.

Ownership of the operators is changing at the same time. The state is divesting 80 per cent of GAMCEL, its mobile operator, to YCell, and the share investment and network modernisation agreement was signed in July 2026, covering nationwide 4G and 5G radio access, core network, OSS/BSS and billing systems, hybrid power at tower sites and fraud management. GAMTEL separately entered a public-private partnership with SYSROAD SA HOLDING to expand core network capacity (December 2025).

Private capital has also built what the state did not: the country's first data centre, QGroup House, was inaugurated in April 2026 by a domestic operator whose partnership with Huawei runs back 17 years. What the industry has to build to is thin — the standards bureau's catalogue carries almost no ICT-specific standards, its electrotechnical section consisting of adopted IEC entries only (2022) — and so is the labour pool, with the Banjul Google Developer Group counting fewer than a thousand members (2026). A draft e-commerce policy and strategy reached a national validation workshop on 24 September 2025 under World Bank WARDIP support.

### Innovation ecosystem

The Gambia does not appear in the international innovation measures at all: it is in none of the 133 economies profiled in the Global Innovation Index 2024, nor in the 2019-2023 editions.

The domestic startup base is small and largely private. AfriLabs lists technology hubs including The Disruptive Lab, Gambia Tech and Startup Incubator Gambia (2026), alongside the older Banjul vocational training and incubation centre handed over by India in 2017, which teaches ICT among its disciplines. Tracxn lists 185 Gambian startups, seventeen of them funded and most in banking and fintech, with no material venture funding round recorded for the country (2026).

Government support is at the framework stage. The December 2025 budget speech named a Digital Startups Policy, a National Data Policy and a Digital Government Policy and Roadmap among the instruments government said it was strengthening. The most ambitious commitment of the period remains a memorandum: a January 2025 agreement with the Kalp Foundation to build a blockchain-based digital public infrastructure platform branded "Gambia One".

## Capacity

### Literacy

Only 13.2% of Gambian schools had internet access for teaching in 2025, 15.6% had computers for pedagogical use and 57% of lower basic schools had electricity. The Education Sector Policy 2016–2030 commits the school system to teaching programming, database design, website administration and network-systems administration, and to integrating ICT into teaching and learning generally; the distance between that commitment and those three figures is the country's school digital-literacy position as at September 2026.

The same policy carries no count of schools with working ICT laboratories, no connectivity figure and no count of ICT-qualified teachers, so the central curricular commitment runs without a delivery baseline against which any of it can be measured. School ICT access also sits as one strand of a whole-sector policy rather than in a dedicated chapter or a standalone school connectivity programme.

Education is nonetheless one of The Gambia's three best-scoring governance sub-categories, at 61.8 out of 100 in 2023 and 11th of 54 African states, with education quality at 57.4. On the same index for 2023, enrolment scores 48.5 and completion 58.3, both up around ten points over the decade, leaving enrolment below the halfway mark against African peers even as it climbs.

Outside the curriculum, an artificial-intelligence education app was launched for Gambian schools in November 2025 by Africa Missions Global, working with the Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education as partner, offering students registration on an artificial-intelligence course, and the government signed a framework agreement with Smart Africa in December 2025 for a digital academy training policymakers, civil servants, young people and women. In financial services, the Central Bank's National Financial Inclusion Strategy carries a financial literacy and consumer protection working group and a gender-sensitive consumer protection framework aimed at women and youth.

### Training and skills

The Civil Service University's ICT department, running since the late 1990s, lists a national diploma in computer science alongside Cisco network-certification and cyber-security courses, under a Civil Service Reform Programme 2018–2027 that requires capacity building after its predecessor's did not take place. That reform programme provides for ICT training across ministries, a human-resource management information system, e-government and systematic closure of civil-service capacity gaps, and runs to 2027.

The National Accreditation and Quality Assurance Authority names eleven institutions accredited to offer degrees, among them the University of The Gambia, the Civil Service University and the University of Applied Science, Engineering and Technology, and warns that unaccredited degrees are not recognised by government. The University of The Gambia's School of Information, Technology and Communications offers BSc degrees in Computer Science, Information Systems and Telecommunications, alongside six-month diplomas in networking and cloud, web development, data science, cybersecurity, artificial intelligence and advanced web applications. The teaching workforce is the strongest part of the system that feeds it: human resources in education scored 88.0 out of 100 in 2023, 20th of 54 African states.

None of the degree-granting institutions with dedicated ICT provision publishes enrolment or graduation figures for those programmes, and none of the foreign channels supplying Gambians with digital and technical places publishes completion or placement data.

Most training that is counted at all is donor-delivered and small. Nearly 300 law-enforcement officers had been trained on the automated fingerprint identification system through a pool of ten national trainers by May 2026. Twenty-five planners from more than ten government institutions were trained on demographic modules, software and databases in August 2026. More than twenty health staff were trained on event-based surveillance signal detection and reporting over two days in December 2025. India has awarded 302 scholarships to Gambian students for online undergraduate, postgraduate and diploma study since March 2020. The employment ministry signed memoranda with three training institutions to deliver three years of intermediate and advanced digital skills training, reported on 29 September 2026.

### Research institutions

The Ministry of Higher Education, Research, Science and Technology signed a memorandum with the African Institute for Mathematical Sciences at Mbour on 10 December 2025 to establish an AIMS satellite centre in The Gambia, with a stated roadmap towards an autonomous centre of excellence. Its scope covers access for Gambian students to AIMS postgraduate programmes in mathematical sciences, data science and artificial intelligence at the network's centres in Senegal, Rwanda and South Africa, training for Gambian university lecturers and secondary-school teachers, collaborative research and shared access to datasets and technological resources.

Domestic computing research capacity rests on the University of The Gambia's ICT school and its three undergraduate degree programmes. The most substantial recent applied research on the labour market comes instead from the Gambia Bureau of Statistics' trend volume covering 2023 to 2026, which was financed by the World Bank through the HISWACA project with ILO technical support.

## Inclusion

### Access to services

Inclusion and equality is The Gambia's only top-ten governance sub-category, at 62.8 out of 100 and 10th of 54 African states in 2023 after a 14.5-point gain over the decade, with equal access to public services at 55.6 and 13th of 54. What is distributed evenly is nonetheless thin: access to banking sits among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators.

The Persons with Disabilities Act 2021 addresses information and communications in general terms and sets no digital or web accessibility standard. A framework for monitoring the Act, accessibility included, was validated in February 2026. Assistive equipment comes from outside government: Ecobank Gambia handed a refurbished ICT laboratory of fifteen machines running the NVDA screen reader to the Gambia Organization of the Visually Impaired on 11 October 2025.

Cash transfer reach is widening. The Nafa programme moved into 10 new districts in November 2025, with nationwide expansion planned for 2026, paying rural households cashlessly through a mobile money platform since January 2026, off the national social registry.

PURA's toll-free 148 call centre, with a documented complaint-handling and escalation flow, is the complaint route for regulated utilities. Draft regulations giving consumers a right to complain, with timelines, escalation, hearings, appeals and protection against retaliation, went out for comment in April 2026 and are not in force. The state utility's app takes complaints and photographed fault reports alongside bill payment (April 2026), and the Ombudsman opened complaints to online filing in February 2015.

The National Migration Policy 2020-2030 is the standing framework for refugees, statelessness, non-discrimination, identity documents, border management and migration data, with a dedicated chapter on each, above the Refugee Act 2008's statutory entitlement to a refugee identity card and Convention travel document. UNHCR recorded 4,214 people of concern at 31 May 2026.

The Universal Access and Service Policy 2020 provides for a Universal Access and Service Fund and Board and directed priority to rural communities, women, youth, persons with disabilities, schools and health facilities, its headline commitment universal broadband coverage within three years of 2020. School ICT access is one strand of the whole-sector Education Sector Policy 2016-2030 rather than a dedicated chapter or a standalone connectivity programme.

### Digital divides

The size of The Gambia's digital gender gap is not published. The National Gender Policy 2025-2034 names the digital gender divide as a problem but puts no figure on it, so the country's principal gender instrument carries no measure of the gap it commits to closing, and GSMA's Mobile Gender Gap Report 2025 does not survey the country. The policy is otherwise substantial: dated June 2024 and funded by the African Development Bank, it succeeds the expired Gender and Women Empowerment Policy 2010-2020 and carries the constitutional and legislative provisions, the ratified global and regional instruments, and a situational analysis running across economic development, gender-based violence, education, health, justice and governance.

Measurement is arriving from outside. The World Bank released Gambian microdata from the Global Findex Database 2025 on 1 October 2025, drawn from 2024 fieldwork and adding nationally representative readings of mobile ownership, internet use, digital safety and account access alongside a new Digital Connectivity Tracker; the Bank also publishes a Gambia Gender Data Landscape setting gender-equity indicators against regional and income-group peers. The national accounting does not answer the question: the Bureau of Statistics' communication statistics report gives mobile subscribers only, with no internet subscription count or penetration rate.

The divide that is measured is geographic. The national digital economy masterplan records internet use in urban areas at almost twice the rural rate and extends the fibre backbone outward from the Greater Banjul Area. The services that digital access rests on show the same shape, in the gap between urban and rural electricity access and in the small minority of schools with internet for teaching or computers for pedagogical use.

Intervention on the gender divide is recent and thin. In October 2025 the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy launched a project with the Digital Cooperation Organization to support women-owned small businesses with digital skills and business capacity. The regional alliance opened a workshop to pilot gender impact assessment tools for digital policy, with Eswatini and The Gambia as pilot countries (2026).

## Data

### National statistics

Statistical capacity is one of The Gambia's fastest-improving governance measures, scoring 60.1 out of 100 in 2023, 14th of 54 African states after a 33.8-point rise over the decade, the seventh most improved of its 96 indicators. The gain is uneven: on the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators the country scores above 89% on data use but only 20-49% on data sources (2023), the pillar covering the censuses, surveys and administrative records everything else is built from. Three or more household, health and labour force surveys have been fielded in the last ten years, but no agricultural survey and no business survey, leaving the productive economy the least surveyed part of the system.

The 2024 population and housing census, the country's first fully digital one, counted 2,422,712 people in its preliminary results (May-June 2024). Output has quickened since. GBoS published the National Food Security Survey Report 2026 in May 2026, covering all eight Local Government Areas, and the fifth round of the Labour Force Survey in July 2026. That round puts the working-age population at 1,434,115, employment at 733,364 and the unemployment rate at 6.2% (March 2026), with underutilisation far above the headline, at LU3 23.6% and LU4 32.1%. Both it and the bureau's three-round comparison were funded by the World Bank through HISWACA, with ILO technical support.

The governance layer has not kept pace. NSDS III, published September 2023, concedes weaknesses in coordination, in modernisation and in data sharing and protection, and records that 35.3% of members of the national statistical system were unaware the Statistics Act 2005 existed. STATAFRIC's peer review of 17 November 2025 names modernising the statistical legal framework among the areas requiring sustained attention, while crediting dissemination through the IMF's enhanced General Data Dissemination System and a National Summary Data Page. The Act itself sits in the bureau's library as an image-only scan with no text layer.

Communication Statistics 2024, dated June 2025, reports mobile subscribers only, carrying no internet subscription count or penetration rate despite a section headed for them, and electricity access has been monitored from census figures pending a Multi-Tier Framework survey planned under the National Energy Compact (2025).

### Open data

The Gambia's own Government Open Data Strategy 2024-2027 states that government has no legal framework for open data, no centralised registry and no data-quality software (2024) — and that the missing legal framework has left some individuals and organisations reluctant to share data, even within government. The strategy was formulated with the e-Governance Academy and sets its KPI targets against 31 December 2026; it proposes a secure data-exchange pilot of the X-Road kind. It was put in place by the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy for 2024 to 2027. Statistics are the exception: a 2018 dissemination policy provides free public-use microdata through an online catalogue after registration, with licensed and enclave tiers for more sensitive files, though that catalogue held only three studies on 2 July 2026.

Across the twenty-three Open Data Inventory categories assessed for The Gambia in 2024 the country averages 4.2 out of 10, with three categories at zero and only seven reaching 5.5 or above.

The zeros are telecommunications and digital statistics, energy statistics, and crime and justice statistics, each scoring nothing out of ten in the 2024 assessment. Social and health categories score little better: health facilities 3 out of 10, health outcomes 3.5, population 4 and education facilities 4 (2024). The strength is financial and

macroeconomic — balance of payments, government finance and price indexes each score 7, and banking statistics 6.5 (2024) — which is the profile of a system whose publishing habits answer to external surveillance rather than to domestic demand.

The statutory basis is in place; the practice is not. The Access to Information Act 2021 is the statute under which the Information Commission was established, and the data protection bill laid before the National Assembly also makes it the data protection authority. Against that, Disclosure of Public Records scores 27.1 out of 100 in 2023, 36th of 54 African states, and Accessibility of Public Records 29.7, both among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators after a decade of improvement. The Commission is procuring a communication strategy to raise public awareness of that Act and of the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025, funded by UNFPA under the Peacebuilding Fund (August 2026).

### Use of satellite data

The national meteorological service took delivery of Meteosat Third Generation PUMA and ClimSA satellite reception stations on 30 August 2024, enabling continued reception of Meteosat Third Generation model data and satellite imagery. The upgrade arrived as project delivery rather than national procurement: the stations were supplied under the EU-funded ClimSA programme and contracted by the African Union to the Swiss firm Tecnavia.

The geospatial platform in use for Gambian land and agriculture is likewise a donor's. FAO's 2024 monitoring framework for the ROOTS project documents a platform tracking rice, vegetable gardens, mangroves, forestry, agroforestry and infrastructure through a National Land Cover Reference System, used for agricultural and natural-resource planning.

Satellite capability also turns up where it would not be looked for. The 2026 budget speech reports satellite internet installed in health facilities specifically to improve birth registration rates, naming connectivity as the lever for a civil-registration outcome rather than for care delivery, and the national Early Warnings for All roadmap endorsed in October 2025 sets the country's multi-hazard coverage ambition.

## Geopolitics

### US / hyperscaler activities

United States engagement with The Gambia's digital sector runs almost entirely through one company, and it has turned into friction: the minister told the National Assembly that the United States State Department, embassy and Starlink had pressed persistently for a licence while his ministry reviewed the application (July 2025), with the licence still unissued.

It began cordially and at ministerial level. The Foreign Ministry recorded a virtual meeting between Foreign Minister Mamadou Tangara and Elon Musk on bridging the digital divide, followed by an in-person meeting in Banjul on 23 July 2024 with Starlink's director of global licensing and activation, Ben MacWilliams, who also met the leadership of PURA and the minister then responsible for the sector. Nothing in that engagement committed either side to anything, and the two years since have been spent on a licence rather than on a deployment.

### China activities

The clearest Chinese presence in The Gambia's digital build is commercial rather than sovereign: Huawei, the 17-year technology partner of QCell, was at the inauguration of QGroup House, the privately built facility opened in April 2026 that holds the country's first data centre and was presented as Gambian-owned innovation.

State to state, the record is a debt. A China Eximbank concessional loan signed in December 2017 for the national broadband network was on-lent to the state operator GAMTEL and secured against a cash balance the lender could reach. It did not sit lightly on the public finances: the borrowing took the government through its ceiling on contracting new non-concessional external debt, and GAMTEL fell into arrears on interest before being required to maintain and replenish a dedicated escrow account to service it.

China's own account of its role is broader than anything the record carries. The embassy in Banjul names the National Broadband Network and 5G networks among the projects Chinese companies undertake in the country (October 2023) without naming a company, a contract, a value or a completion date for any of them.

### EU activities

The European Union is the largest declared external funder of The Gambia's public digital systems and has never sized that work. Its EUR 193 million grant envelope for 2021–2027 under the Global Gateway strategy carries no digital-specific figure, and digitalisation reaches the Commission's own statement of the programme as a single clause — enabling digitalisation in business and public administration — with no project or instrument attached to it (September 2026).

What has been sized is small and precise. EUR 493,346 of EU funding built a DHIS2-based web platform tracking 237 indicators across the seven pillars of the Recovery-Focused National Development Plan, with real-time collection, analysis and reporting across ministries, departments and agencies and training for the transition to programme-based budgeting (April 2026).

The larger visible delivery is policing infrastructure rather than administration. The Gambia's criminal Automated Fingerprint Identification System went live on 28 April 2026 under the EU-funded, INTERPOL-implemented WAPIS programme, with renovated Criminal Records Office premises and nearly 300 officers trained around it (May 2026).

Cooperation runs on a Multiannual Indicative Programme for 2021–2027, amended at mid-term review on 31 October 2024, with annual action plans for 2022, 2023 and 2024, and the envelope is grouped under five headings — democratic transition, sustainable growth and jobs, energy, human development and migration management; none of them is digital. European money also sits under pieces of the data estate counted elsewhere in this report: the Meteosat and ClimSA reception stations delivered to the Department of Water Resources, the peer review of the national statistical system implemented by Expertise France, and the National Digital Addressing Policy developed with the AU-EU Digital for Development Hub and Estonia's eGovernance Academy.

### Gulf/UAE activities

Gulf-linked financing of Gambian connectivity runs through a multilateral bank rather than a state: the Islamic Development Bank counts The Gambia among the beneficiaries of the ECOWAS fibre optic backbone it financed, providing national fibre infrastructure and cross-border connection with neighbouring countries in cooperation with the African Development Bank and the World Bank, though its account names no date, sum or contractor for the Gambian leg.

### India activities

India's recorded involvement in Gambian digital public infrastructure is a memorandum: New Delhi's own brief on relations with The Gambia records a memorandum of understanding on digital public infrastructure cooperation signed on 3 October 2024.

### Digital sovereignty

The Gambia's new identity register sits on home soil in a facility its supplier built, financed and helps run: at the June 2026 launch officials said the database is physically hosted in The Gambia, protected under Gambian law and owned by the state, and the President said ownership of the whole system remains with Gambians although Margins ID Group supplied the technology, financing and long-term operational support. What the state holds outright comes at the end of the contract, when all project assets are transferred to the government after eight years. A year earlier the President had promised a unified identity system locally designed, built, operated and managed by government services, replacing the concession contract for the national ID (June 2025). Whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the identity system, or can exit its operating contract, was not on record as at September 2026.

Foreign partners have been given access to the security of the critical systems themselves. Under a January 2026 memorandum, the Bahraini firm CTM360 is to conduct cybersecurity assessments across the regulator's IT infrastructure and other critical national infrastructure, and to offer its platform free to all Gambian critical infrastructure operators. The terms on which the CTM360 memorandum and the Margins identity contract govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

For AI, the partners are being lined up before the policy: the higher education minister agreed with the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority in September 2026 to draw up a memorandum on AI training, scholarships and curriculum support, and The Gambia's ambassador in Geneva announced cooperation with China's Guizhou province that includes establishing a national data laboratory in The Gambia on the Guizhou model (August 2026).

At the continental layer, the National Data Policy validated in July 2025 is aligned with the African Union Data Policy Framework, with cross-border data flows among the areas stakeholders strengthened.

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